StoryCast: Research Document

Purpose and Audience

StoryCast is a three page microsite for audio and video stories. It aims to allow people to enjoy each story in their preferred manner: listening, watching or reading.

Target audience:

- Those who like thought provoking, human stories
- Users with mobile phones or small screens.
- Individuals with low vision or blind or those who require strong contrast and need to use a screen reader.
- Individuals requiring captioning and/or transcripts
- People who are deaf
- Individuals who use a keyboard rather than the mouse to move about.

Accessibility Research

StoryCast is compliant with WCAG 2.1 level AA, guidelines of the Web Accessibility Initiative (WAI) of the w3C. WCAG is based on four principles: Perceivable, Operable, Understandable, and Robust.

Each of these principles influences StoryCast as follows:

Perceivable

- Audio stories have a full text transcript on the page (WCAG 1.2.1).
- Video stories are provided with captions (WCAG 1.2.2).
- Images have useful alt text (WCAG 1.1.1). -
- Text has a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1 (WCAG 1.4.3). Ink (#242321) on paper (#F8F5EF) is 14.4:1. Oxblood (#963D48) on paper is 6.3:1.

Operable

- Accessible with the keyboard (WCAG 2.1.1).
- A skip link is provided for users who want to skip the menu (WCAG 2.4.1).
- Links and controls have a visible focus outline (WCAG 2.4.7).
- Nothing plays automatically.

Understandable

- Have headings and one h1 per page.

- A link text is used to explain where a link goes.
- The language of the page will be set to English.

Robust

- Semantic HTML (header, nav, main, article, section, footer) is good with screen readers.
- ARIA is intended for the use that goes beyond HTML—such as for areas for navigation.

3. Design Rationale

Concept

StoryCast is structured as an unobtrusive online magazine. The interface is supportive of the story, which is the main character. No autoplaying media, carousels or heavy effects.

Color palette

Paper (#F8F5EF): a warm tone background that is softer on the eyes than white.

- Ink (#242321): strong contrast for text.
- Oxblood (#963D48): One neutral tone for links, labels and numbers.
- Stone (#DDD5C9): thin dividers and subtle borders.

Typography

- Newsreader (serif) for headings and story titles, to give an editorial feel.

Inter (sans-serif) for menus, labels and body text, it is clear and easy to read.

- Text sizes are measured in rem units, thus adjusting according to the user's browser settings.

Navigation

- A simple menu, common to all three pages.
- Consistent footer throughout the site, giving users a sense of where they are.
- A breadcrumb at the top of the story page.

Layout

- Limited width centered column for easy reading.
- The header and menus are built using flexbox.
- Grid is used for the story entries, the footer, and the access list.
- When the container is narrow, a container query on the story list will switch each of the three columns to one.

Signature detail

A small accent colored index number (01, 02, 03) is displayed in each story. This is an alternative to the usual cards, and adds to the site's identity. The numbers are not visible to screen readers, since they are just decorative.

Code structure

- Use Sass/tokens for colors, typography and spacing.
- Class .story-entry__title, for instance.- BEM for instance .story-entry__title.
- Cascade layers: reset, base, layout, components and utilities.

References

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The "WWW Consortium" is the World Wide Web Consortium. (2018). The following key points explain how Web content accessibility guidelines (WCAG) 2.1 (https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG21/) apply to this document:

World Wide Web Consortium (W3C). (n.d.). Web accessibility initiative (WAI), www.w3.org/WAI/.